

"Modernization Theory"

One of the most significant events of the 1950's was decolonization. Slavery, continuous resource collection, raw material extraction, i.e. economic exploitation, were prominent features of the colonial period, left the colonized areas remaining underdeveloped.

After decolonization, a prominent theory came with the idea to modernize the poor countries - named "Modernization Theory."

Modernization, a theory from the 1950s and 1960s based on capitalism, explains how traditional societies changes to become modern ones. The idea of modernization incorporates the full spectrum of the transition and a drastic transformation that a traditional society has to undergo in order to become modern.

In Africa's case, modernization meant trying to follow the footstep of development as Europe, which had previously colonized much of the continent. The footstep considers industrialization, capitalism, free trade etc. The process is like that____

Poor Countries -----> developed/modern countries.

(transformation/modernization)

Some people believed that the responsibility for developing Africa belonged to European countries (the former colonial powers). These countries often suggested—either directly or indirectly—that Africa was underdeveloped because Black people were naturally less capable of handling social, economic, and technological progress. However, this idea is wrong and harmful.

These societies had well-organized economies with skilled farmers, artists, blacksmiths, weavers, carvers, and traditional healers. They also used advanced techniques to preserve food which shows that Africa was on its own development path before European influence.

The West wanted to redirect Africa's development to match their own interests. Believing they were more "advanced," they took it upon themselves to guide Africa's progress in a new direction. They argued that Africa had to go through certain fixed stages of development. This idea is explained in Rostow's theory, which outlines 5 stages____

- 1. Primitive society:** The stage is characterized by subsistence farming and barter trade.
- 2. Preparation for take-off:** The characteristics of the stage are; specialization, production of surplus goods and trade. Transport infrastructure is developed to support trade. The stage encourages savings and investment.
- 3. Take-off:** At this stage industrialization increases and the economy switches from agriculture to manufacturing.
- 4. Drive to maturity:** At this stage the economy diversifies into new areas and there is less



reliance on imports.

5. Period of mass consumption: At this stage, the economy gears on mass production and service sector becomes increasingly dominating.

Five stages of Rostow's Theory is quite controversial. The theory is largely criticized. **The criticisms are ____**

1. The model is "Too Theoretical" and assumes "Linear Development Path."

The model is too theoretical which means that the model can't explain the real world scenario. Because by assuming linear development path, the model predicts that the process occurs step by step that is the process follows a straight development path. But it's not true. It's not possible to categorize the complex development process into 5 categories. The steps can be overlapping i. e. Economies can be on 2 or 3 stages at the same time. Such as, In reality, many African economies focus on areas like agriculture, manufacturing, and tourism, which don't fit neatly into the stages suggested by Rostow's theory.

In the case of Bangladesh, the country is in the 5 stages mentioned above at the same time.

- Primitive Society: local communities trade occurs.
- Preparation For Take-Off: trade occurs with Korea, Japan due to the overproduction of some products.
- Take-Off: EPZ are on this category.
- Drive to maturity: Diversification in Garment, Leather, Shrimp, Software industries.
- Mass Consumption: Increase in the upper middle class and rising of higher class; service sector's booming.

2. Oversimplified View Of Social Change.

Rostow automatically assumed that, the process is desirable. But, that may not be true. The change can also be imposed. People often resist change because it feels uncertain and threatening, and they prefer to stick with what they know. The people can resist the change due to several reasons such as...



★ Loss of Agricultural Land.

As land is limited, then in order to go from stage 2 to stage 3, there creates conflict between agricultural sector & manufacturing sector. The loss of Agricultural land result in the reduction of food production and rural to urban migration creating unemployment or increase the demand of informal jobs. That is, the process changes the land and labor pattern.

★ Expansion in manufacturing sector Comes with Environmental Hazard.

- RMG sector has destroyed rivers like Buriganga, Shitalakha.
- Air pollution, sound pollution Health Hazard. In recent years, About one and a half lakh people had died due to airborine diseases.
- Manufacturing needs powerplant which serviced by coal to produce electricity which is dangerous for health.
- Health sector disasters can occur because of huge government expenditure.

★ Automation/AI.

These are the result of modernization which can lead to a structural unemployment due to low skill.

3. Deculturization of Traditionall values.

The process is about the abandonment of an individual's cultural values in favour of that of the former colonisers. Put differently, the development will occur by abandoning traditional society's norms /values/cultures and by adopting Western values/culture/ modernism.

Like as, in Bangladesh,

- We learn with British designed education system.
- Farmers has their own seed preservation system, which is now lost and farmers became dependent on market system.

By saying "primitive", the theory neglected the traditional agricultural system.



4. The theory refers that, changes should be made with the help of external forces.

The another major weaknesses of the modernization theory is that it is based on deterministic reason which states that within the linear model of socio-economic

development, changes are initiated externally. This idea refers that, it is the responsibility of the West to modernize the Africa or poor countries. The idea ignores the role of local people and conditions play in development. It lets foreign powers decide how a country should develop.

★ Top - Down Process.

This theory is criticized because it overlooks the importance of involving poor communities in efforts to reduce poverty. By ignoring their input and participation, modernization pushes them aside and loses their creativity, support, and commitment to development projects. That is, poor are never on the centered of the development, the process run by trade motive. Policies are draft in Washington and sent to Africa.

★ Eurocentric.

One of the most important critic of the theory is that, the theory is "Eurocentric", which refers that the development process is based on European market demand.

Africa supplies raw materials (tea, coffee, cocoa) to Europe and European multinational Corporation extracts raw materials from Africa. This leads in the growing number of Western MNC's and the profit of the MNC's is vast.

The process altered the African land, labor and agricultural pattern. Because of the reduction of food production, Africa became dependent on importing food which also imported from Europe. There left no wonder, why Africa is poor! The development of Africa depends on the demand of Europe. And obviously, the process is about trade.

★ Role Of Foreign Aids.

The theory assumes that, modernization is a result of development aid from the developed countries. Africa received billions of dollar aid. Then the question arises, Why Africa is still poor?

Africa is poor because of its Import dependency and foreign currency outflow. African import dependency can be explained with the history of colonization extraction which altered African land, labor and agricultural system. So, foreign aid can not make poor countries as developed ones! It is also notable that, the aid is not that type of aid always. The aid is basically a loan with interest rate and some other conditions.



5. Priorities The Role Of Technology.

The modernization theory considers technology as the major source of development. That is, development is defined by technology - Technological Development.

Marx argued that, the difference between modern world and Africa is determined by Technology and international labor division.

Africa is rich in mineral resources such as Aluminium, Rubber, Copper, Rubber, Steel.

Europe produces car, military weapon, Aircrafts by sourcing the mineral resources from Africa.

These products are highly expensive, highly valued and high end products.

Africa Supplies the raw materials which are low valued, low end products and needed to be processed such as tea, coffee (in Europe).

That is, the West makes final products for both itself and Africa, while Africa mainly supplies raw materials and supports its own basic needs.

Africa cannot produce the final products because of lack of technology.

Poorer countries do not have access to technology because____

- Technology is highly expensive.
- Poor countries have inadequate capital.
- The tendency of increased patent law in the recent world.
- Royalty fees should be given to use the technology.
- The case of selling and buying technology arises.

As a result of these, technological gap cannot be jumped by poorer countries.

Moreover, While African workers work in mining, European workers work as an Engineer - creates the situation of "Division of Labor."

For example, the labor of Bangladesh is low paid, low skilled manual while the labor of Germany is highly skilled. The case of "Division of Labor."

The above discussion says that, the modernization theory is not the appropriate one to modernize Africa or the other poorer countries.

To move beyond poverty, Africa and the poorer countries need to stop relying on modern ideas alone and develop its own approaches to progress. Ending poverty requires more than just replacing traditional ways with modern ones.

